

A thousand rupees will buy you a computer at Mumbai's Lamington Road. Astonished? Well, here comes the fine print. Don't expect the bells and whistles, but for that kind of money, you can pick up a working 386 complete with a black and white monitor.

Before you dismiss the thought, consider this: How much computing power is adequate? Let's be honest here—all we do is run standard office applications, listen to music, surf and communicate via e-mail and instant messengers. People are slowly waking up to that fact. Believe it or not, there's a huge market for secondhand computers. You just have to know where to look.

The buyers and the sellers

Digging into the world of secondhand computers is an eye-opener. You can pick up an old, working 386-based computer with a black-and-white monitor for a mere Rs 1,000, and a 486 comes for an additional Rs 500. Ask Jitubhai Patel, who calls himself *Jitubhai Joone Computerwale* (old computer seller). Working out of a cramped office in a Mumbai suburb, he sells almost everything—right from old working computers, down to every component of a PC. As he puts it, "Why pay Rs 4,500 for a brand new monitor, when you can buy an older one for Rs 1,800 from me"? Though the prices go up with the specifications, here's the insider

secret—it's still not stratospheric. Second-hand resellers such as Jitubhai will sell you a Pentium III with a multimedia kit for Rs 12,000.

So how do resellers source such systems? The primary source of such hardware are corporates—especially banks. Many of them get rid of their old systems routinely, after the extensive computerisation they have gone through over the past decade or so. Both, Jitubhai as well as Sanjay and Kalpesh Jain, of Rishab Computers, Lamington Road, Mumbai, routinely pick up their hardware through such house-clearing sales.

Other sources include schools and people who sell their PCs or parts of it, while

The much-neglected secondhand PC market is slowly gaining in popularity, owing to the practical no-nonsense options that they offer...

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